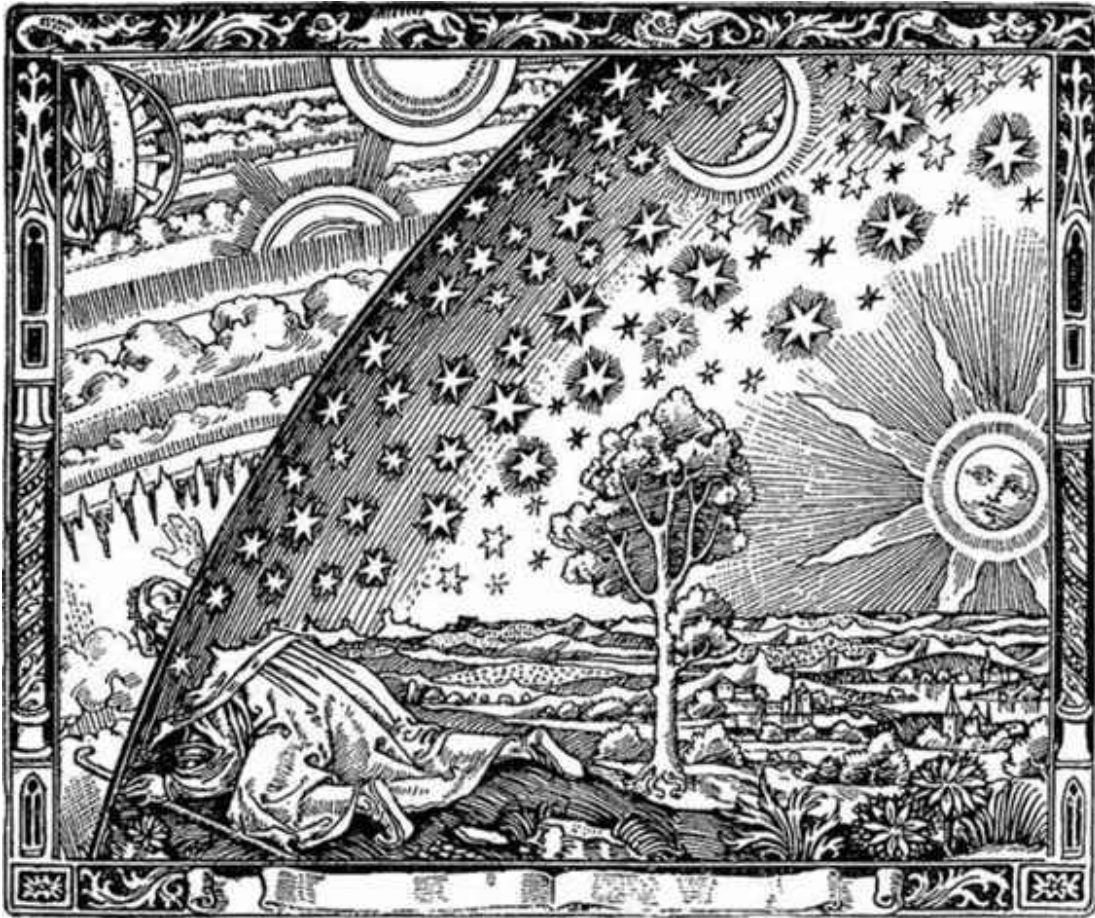


Locke and the limits of the knowable



While Hobbes prepared the ground for British empiricism, it was John Locke who first laid out its arguments. In his *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1689), Locke set out to discover the limits of what we can know. We can only apprehend ‘ideas’ (by which he meant sensations, feelings and so on, as well as intellectual ideas) in our own consciousness. But innate ideas, he reasoned, are an impossibility, as they cannot exist before there is a mechanism to think them, so our senses are the only source of information of external reality. That being the case, our knowledge depends on our sensory experience of the world; it is experience that determines the limits of what humans can know, no matter what actually exists externally. Locke believed that at birth we have faculties of sensory perception and a capacity for rational thought, but our minds are otherwise a *tabula rasa* or blank slate, with no innate ideas of the world. As well as

providing a counter-argument to Descartes's rationalism, this concept also influenced Locke's political philosophy (see [The social contract](#)).